# Morning Edition

Sunday, 13 September 2026

*Ten stories curated through your lens on ocean governance, hydrospatial science, and SIDS equity.*



⚡ ACTIONABLE — CLOSES TODAY

01

## The fellowship that builds officials like the one you used to be closes its window today

*The UN's ocean governance fellowship for Small Island Developing States closes its 2027 call today, and it's exactly the pipeline your former department in Victoria needs flagged before the window shuts, not a programme you'd apply to yourself.*

STORY NOTES

The UN Division for Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea runs a fellowship for one specific profile: a government official, 25 to 45 years old, degree in hand, working ocean affairs or UNCLOS implementation in a Small Island Developing State. Applications for the 2027 session close today, 13 September 2026.

Three months at UN Headquarters in New York, typically September to November, built around a country-specific research paper and an ocean governance matrix the fellow takes home. The programme pushes explicitly for 50/50 gender balance.

You are past the age band and no longer inside government, so this isn't yours to apply for. It is squarely something to put in front of the Department of Blue Economy today, even as a same-day email rather than a completed nomination, since the fellowship pipeline itself outlasts any single closing date.

`https://www.un.org/oceancapacity/content/unnf-ocean-governance-fellowship-sids`

STORY ARTICLE

Today is the deadline. That fact alone is worth sitting with, because a fellowship like this rarely announces its closing date loudly, and most of the people it is built for find out after the window has already shut.

The programme is narrow by design. Applicants must be government officials, 25 to 45, holding a university degree, working directly on ocean affairs, UNCLOS implementation, or maritime policy in a Small Island Developing State, with a nominating authority confirming the work supports a real national initiative. In exchange, the fellow gets three months at UN Headquarters in New York, a curriculum of workshops and scenario exercises led by UN staff and visiting experts, and two concrete deliverables to bring home: a country-specific research paper and an ocean governance matrix.

You moved through exactly this kind of institutional door without a programme this deliberately built existing in this form. UNDP regional project management, the IOC-UNESCO focal point role, the International Seabed Authority contact point, and eventually Director General for Maritime Boundary Delimitation, each one built on the last, mostly through relationships and appointment rather than a structured pipeline. That this fellowship now exists as a named, repeatable mechanism says something about how the field has professionalised since you started in it, and it is worth noting in a Shorelines piece on how the institutional infrastructure around SIDS ocean governance careers has changed in twenty years.

Name the standard objection before answering it. Critics of programmes like this call them extraction dressed as capacity building: fly a junior official to New York for three months, at real cost, rather than fund training capacity in the islands themselves, and the fellow's expertise may or may not survive contact with an under-resourced home ministry afterward. That criticism has weight. The nominating-authority requirement is a partial answer, not a full one. It anchors the fellow's output to a stated national deliverable rather than a resume line, but it does nothing to guarantee the ocean governance matrix gets used once the fellow is back at their desk in Victoria, Suva, or Bridgetown, competing against the same staffing shortages that sent them to New York in the first place.

The BBNJ Agreement has been in force since January, and its Preparatory Commission is drafting the operating rules SIDS will need trained officials to actually work with by COP1 in January 2027. That is the practical stake here, not an abstract capacity-building good. A state without an official who has spent real time inside UN process on exactly this treaty family will be negotiating catch-up from day one of implementation, and a three-month fellowship that produces one such official is a meaningfully cheap hedge against that outcome.

The concrete move today is not a full application, since the window is closing as this goes to print. It is one email: to Seychelles' Department of Blue Economy, naming a candidate and this deadline, and a note in SHORE's own calendar to raise the next cycle six months out rather than on the day it closes again.

`https://www.un.org/oceancapacity/content/unnf-ocean-governance-fellowship-sids`

SEYCHELLES GDP PER CAPITA, IMF, APRIL 2026

**$17,670**

# The blue economy just gave you Africa's highest GDP per capita and a rising debt line in the same report

*Seychelles now posts the highest GDP per capita in Africa on the back of tuna, tourism, and its own blue bond, and that exact number is what keeps locking Seychelles out of the concessional finance a small, exposed island still needs.*

STORY NOTES

Seychelles' GDP per capita reached roughly US$17,670 by April 2026, the highest in Africa according to the IMF, driven by tuna, tourism, and the blue bond behind a falling public debt ratio. Tourism arrivals grew 13 percent in 2025, with new demand from the Gulf and Asia layering onto established European and Indian markets.

Underneath the headline number, separate reporting this month flags a slowing economy and rising debt as President Herminie inherits a tourism boom that has not yet translated into fiscal breathing room. A new aquaculture push, a broodstock acclimation facility, a sea urchin research facility, and a re-established prawn farm on an outer island, plus a port extension tender and airport redevelopment plans, are the government's answer.

This is the High-Income SIDS Paradox rendered as a single balance sheet: the number that makes Seychelles look wealthy to a donor committee is the same number understating how exposed a 155,000-square-kilometre archipelago of roughly 100,000 people still is to a single bad cyclone season or a coral bleaching event that hits tourism and tuna at once.

STORY ARTICLE

Start with the number, because it is doing real argumentative work: $17,670 GDP per capita, highest on the African continent, reported by the IMF this April. That figure alone reads as a development success story, and in narrow terms it is one. Tourism grew 13 percent last year. The blue bond, the world's first sovereign instrument of its kind when Seychelles issued it, sits behind a public debt ratio that has been falling rather than climbing for several years.

But sit the GDP figure next to this month's other Seychelles headline: a slowing economy and rising debt, reported in the same news cycle, as the new administration works through a tourism boom that has driven revenue without yet resolving the debt position underneath it. Both things are true simultaneously, and that simultaneity is the paradox worth naming precisely rather than gesturing at. A state can hold the continent's highest per-capita income and a fragile fiscal position at the same time, because GDP per capita measures average output over a population of roughly 100,000 people spread across 115 islands, not resilience, and not the concentration risk of an economy built on two sectors, tourism and tuna, both directly exposed to ocean health.

This is where the income-classification filter bites hardest. The World Bank's high-income classification, earned in large part through exactly this GDP-per-capita calculation, is the same classification that routes Seychelles out of concessional Green Climate Fund and GEF windows sized for the "developing country" category more broadly. A cyclone or a coral bleaching event that knocks out a season of tourism revenue does not care what income bracket the World Bank assigned Seychelles last year, but the donor committee deciding whether Seychelles qualifies for concessional adaptation finance does.

Name the objection directly: isn't celebrating a blue bond and falling debt in the same breath as complaining about finance access simply having it both ways? Not quite. The blue bond is Seychelles building its own answer to exactly the exclusion the paradox describes, a market-based instrument raised because concessional public finance windows were closed, not because they were unnecessary. It is evidence for the paradox, not against it. The aquaculture diversification, sea urchin research facility included, is the same logic applied at smaller scale: build resilience with the finance tools that are actually available, since the ones that should be available on vulnerability grounds mostly are not.

For Shorelines, this is the sharpest current version of the argument you have been building: a single country, in a single month, posting both the continent's best GDP-per-capita number and a fiscal position tight enough to make front-page news for the opposite reason. Cite both figures together. Neither on its own makes the case; together, they are the case.

`https://www.riotimesonline.com/seychelles-blue-economy-tuna-debt-2026/`

03

# 1.2 percent. That's the fully protected share of your ocean's most important shark habitat

***An IUCN-led study just mapped 125 critical shark and ray areas across the Western Indian Ocean, including Seychelles' own waters, and found only 1.2 percent of them sit inside a fully protected no-take zone.***

STORY NOTES

The IUCN Shark Specialist Group, led by Jesse Cochran and chair Rima Jabado, with Wildlife Conservation Society scientific director Rhett Bennett contributing, identified 125 Important Shark and Ray Areas across the Western Indian Ocean, covering 2.8 million square kilometres from

South Africa to the Indian subcontinent, Seychelles and the Maldives included. Only 7.1 percent of that area overlaps any marine protected area at all, and just 1.2 percent falls inside a fully protected no-take zone.

The region holds 270 known shark and ray species, of which 46 percent face extinction, against overall Western Indian Ocean marine protection of only 6.4 percent. Researchers built the dataset from a 2023 Durban working session, filling scientific gaps with government and fisheries records and citizen science rather than waiting for complete survey coverage that does not exist.

This is a spatial data problem before it is a policy problem, which is precisely the seam HARMONiSE sits in: the areas exist on a map now, in standardised, evidence-based form, and the gap is turning that map into an enforceable designation.

`https://news.mongabay.com/2026/02/critical-shark-and-ray-habitats-in-western-indian-ocean-largely-unprotected-study/`

STORY ARTICLE

Two numbers carry this story: 125 Important Shark and Ray Areas identified across the Western Indian Ocean, and 1.2 percent of that identified area sitting inside a zone where fishing is actually banned. Everything else is commentary on the gap between those two figures.

The methodology is worth naming because it is a model, not just a finding. Rather than waiting for comprehensive at-sea survey data that will not exist for this region on any policy-relevant timeline, the IUCN Shark Specialist Group built its 125 sites from a working session in Durban, standardised criteria, and a deliberate decision to fold in government records, fisheries logs, and citizen science alongside formal survey data. That is the same evidence-assembly logic HARMONiSE argues for in hydrospatial data more broadly: a defensible spatial dataset built from what already exists and is scattered across institutions, rather than a multi-year survey campaign no single SIDS government can fund alone.

Set this against the BBNJ Agreement's high seas area-based management tool provisions, now moving through Preparatory Commission negotiation ahead of COP1 in January. The Agreement gives states and regional bodies a new legal mechanism to nominate protected areas beyond national jurisdiction, but a nomination needs exactly the kind of standardised, evidence-based spatial case this shark and ray study just produced for a large share of the Western Indian Ocean. The data now exists in a form that could plausibly feed a BBNJ nomination. Whether any regional body picks it up and does that work is a separate, open question.

Name the objection a marine spatial planner would raise immediately: identifying a critical habitat area is not the same as having the political and enforcement capacity to protect it, and 46 percent of regional species already facing extinction despite decades of prior conservation attention suggests identification alone has not been the binding constraint. That is fair, and it is the same critique the MPA effectiveness research elsewhere in this edition levels at 30 by 30 more broadly: designation without enforcement funding is closer to a paper exercise than a conservation outcome. The answer here is not that this study solves the enforcement problem. It is that a state or regional body cannot even begin the BBNJ nomination or national MPA design process without a spatial baseline like this one, and until now that baseline for shark and ray habitat across the Western Indian Ocean did not exist in usable form.

For SHORE, this is a direct pointer to a potential regional partnership: the Shark Specialist Group and WCS built a dataset that a Seychelles-based hydrospatial institute is well positioned to help translate into an actual national or joint management area proposal, in the same institutional lane as the Saya de Malha work you already know from the inside.

`https://news.mongabay.com/2026/02/critical-shark-and-ray-habitats-in-western-indian-ocean-largely-unprotected-study/`

STORY_04.LOG

# 0.1 metres local, 2.5 metres global: the accuracy gap that decides HARMONiSE's next model choice

> **A locally trained satellite bathymetry model is reporting ten times the accuracy of a generalised cross-region model, and that gap is the strongest argument yet for training HARMONiSE's own model on Seychelles' waters rather than importing one.**

STORY NOTES

$ Recent published satellite-derived bathymetry research shows a CNN-Transformer model trained across multiple regions reaching a validation R-squared of 0.65 with root-mean-square error of 2.58 metres, while a single-region CNN model tuned to one turbid coastal environment reports mean absolute error near 0.1 metres at depths to 30 metres. A separate comparison found Random Forest outperforming a standard neural network, with RMSE of 0.93 metres and R-squared of 0.83.

The pattern across all three results is consistent: models trained and calibrated locally beat generalised, multi-region models by roughly an order of magnitude in this depth range.

Satellite-derived bathymetry exists to cover water that ship-based multibeam survey never reaches, which for Seychelles is most of a 1.3-million-square-kilometre EEZ. This accuracy gap is a direct methodology input for HARMONiSE, not background reading.

https://geoawesome.com/satellite-derived-bathymetry-mapping-the-unseen-seafloor-from-space/

STORY ARTICLE

Run the numbers side by side before drawing any conclusion. A CNN-Transformer model trained across multiple regions and tested for cross-region generalisation reports a validation R-squared of 0.65 and RMSE of 2.58 metres. A CNN model trained and tuned to a single turbid coastal environment reports mean absolute error close to 0.1 metres at depths to 30 metres. A third study finds Random Forest, a comparatively simple method, beating a standard artificial neural network on the same task, RMSE 0.93 metres against an R-squared of 0.83. None of these numbers are directly comparable across studies with different validation sets and water conditions, and that caveat matters. But the direction all three point in is the same: local calibration beats generalisation by a wide margin in this specific technique.

This has a concrete implication for HARMONiSE. Satellite-derived bathymetry is the technique that matters most for Seychelles precisely because ship-based multibeam survey, the gold standard, cannot realistically cover a 1.3-million-square-kilometre EEZ at any budget a single institute or even a national government can fund. The seafloor mapping gap Seabed 2030 keeps citing globally is, for Seychelles specifically, mostly a satellite-derived bathymetry gap, since that is the only method with any chance of covering the area at all.

The evidence above argues against importing a pre-trained global model and running it on Seychelles' waters unmodified. A generalised model's 2.5-metre error band may be fine for some applications, coarse EEZ-scale planning, but is not fine for others, precise enough bathymetry to support a BBNJ environmental impact assessment or a fisheries management boundary. The order-of-magnitude accuracy gap between local and generalised models suggests HARMONiSE's methodology should budget for local calibration from the start, not treat it as a later refinement.

Name the objection squarely: local calibration requires ground-truth depth data, in-situ soundings, to train and validate against, and that is exactly the kind of survey-vessel time SIDS institutes cannot afford, which is the whole reason satellite-derived bathymetry is attractive in the first place. That is accurate, and it means satellite-derived bathymetry does not eliminate the resourcing problem, it relocates it. A full multibeam survey of an EEZ is not fundable. A limited set of calibration transects, enough ground-truth points to train and validate a local model, is a categorically smaller ask, and one a single research cruise, a partnership with a passing hydrographic vessel, or a modest grant could plausibly cover.

The practical next step for HARMONiSE's methodology review: read past the abstracts on the CNN-Transformer and Random Forest comparisons cited here, since the specific bands and preprocessing choices behind the accuracy numbers matter more than the headline RMSE figures, and decide now whether the next mapping pilot budgets for a calibration transect before committing to a model architecture.

https://geoawesome.com/satellite-derived-bathymetry-mapping-the-unseen-seafloor-from-space/

05

## Ten percent of the ocean is protected on paper. Less than two shows it

*A new global study measuring actual fish biomass recovery, not paper designation, found that under 2 percent of marine protected areas show real ecological recovery against roughly 10 percent formal coverage, which is the strongest available warning for how BBNJ's coming high seas MPAs could fail the same way.*

> *"Most of the world's marine protected areas fail to safeguard marine life in practice."*

STORY NOTES

New research comparing fish biomass, the total weight of fish on a reef, inside and outside marine protected area boundaries across thousands of shallow coral and rocky reefs worldwide found that while roughly 10 percent of the ocean now carries formal protection, less than 2 percent shows measurable ecological recovery. That 2 percent figure assumes compliance with fishing rules inside the boundary, and researchers note actual compliance is often lower still.

The 2022 Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework, adopted by 196 countries, set the 30 by 30 target on coverage: protect 30 percent of the ocean by 2030. This study is evidence that a coverage target, reported without a matching compliance or outcome metric, can be met on paper while the underlying ecological goal goes almost entirely unmet.

BBNJ's forthcoming high seas area-based management tools inherit this exact design flaw unless COP1 builds enforcement funding into the nomination process itself, not as an afterthought.

`https://phys.org/news/2026-09-oceans.html`

STORY ARTICLE

Two numbers, and the gap between them is the entire finding: roughly 10 percent of the ocean formally protected, under 2 percent showing actual ecological recovery. Researchers reached the second number by measuring fish biomass, comparing reefs inside protected boundaries against reefs outside them, across thousands of shallow coral and rocky reef sites globally. That is a deliberately different measurement than counting protected square kilometres, and it is the more honest one, because a boundary drawn on a map does nothing for a fish population if the fishing inside it continues unchecked.

The 30 by 30 target, adopted by 196 countries under the 2022 Kunming-Montreal framework, is a coverage target. Governments report progress against it in square kilometres designated, not in fish biomass recovered or compliance rates enforced. That reporting structure creates a predictable incentive: designating a protected area is politically visible and comparatively cheap, while funding the patrol vessels, monitoring, and enforcement staff needed to make that designation mean something is expensive, unglamorous, and easy to defer. This study is what that incentive structure produces at scale, measured directly rather than inferred.

The relevance to BBNJ is direct, not analogous. The Agreement's area-based management tool provisions give states and regional bodies a new mechanism to nominate marine protected areas in the high seas, the roughly two-thirds of the ocean outside any national jurisdiction, ahead of COP1 in January 2027. High seas enforcement is structurally harder than coastal enforcement: there is no coastal state with jurisdiction and a navy nearby, only whichever flag states choose to cooperate. If a coastal MPA with a nearby government, a nearby port, and clear jurisdiction still achieves less than 2 percent measurable recovery, a high seas MPA with none of those advantages starts from a worse position, not a better one.

Name the conservation counterargument directly: designating protection, even imperfectly enforced, is still the necessary first step, and coverage numbers build the political case for the funding that compliance eventually needs. That has some truth to it. But if 30 by 30 becomes primarily a coverage-reporting exercise, and this study gives critics a citable, quantified reason to say exactly that, the credibility of the target, and the funding case for BBNJ implementation that depends on that credibility, erodes faster than new MPAs get designated.

The practical argument for a Shorelines piece or a COP1-adjacent brief: cite this study by name when arguing that BBNJ's nomination process needs a mandatory enforcement-funding component attached to every proposed area, not a designation process alone, since the coastal-water precedent this research documents is the clearest available evidence for what happens without one.

https://phys.org/news/2026-09-oceans.html

06

## The clock on BBNJ implementation now has an end date: 22 January 2027

*BBNJ's first Conference of the Parties is now locked to 11-22 January 2027, which gives the treaty's Preparatory Commission a hard sixteen-month runway from entry into force to produce working rules, not an open-ended one.*

STORY NOTES

The BBNJ Agreement's first Conference of the Parties is scheduled for 11 to 22 January 2027, constrained by the treaty's own requirement that COP1 be held within a year of entry into force, which occurred 17 January 2026. That leaves the Preparatory Commission a fixed window, not an open one.

The Commission has already met twice, in April and August 2025, and a third session ran 23 March to 2 April 2026, working through area-based management tool nomination rules, environmental impact assessment thresholds, and the marine genetic resource benefit-sharing mechanism that has never operated at this scale before.

A fixed COP1 date changes the PrepCom's negotiating dynamic from indefinite refinement to a forced choice: settle contested rules by January or hand COP1 unfinished business on day one.

STORY ARTICLE

A treaty entering into force reads like the finish line in most coverage, and BBNJ's January 2026 entry into force got treated that way. It was not. The harder, less visible phase runs through the Preparatory Commission, converting roughly thirty pages of framework text into operating rules for area-based management tools, environmental impact assessment, and a marine genetic resource benefit-sharing mechanism with no real precedent at this scale. What changed this month is that this phase now has a hard deadline: COP1 on 11 to 22 January 2027, fixed by the treaty's own one-year rule rather than negotiated as a target.

That fixed date matters more than it looks like it should. Preparatory negotiations without a binding endpoint tend to drift, since no delegation is forced to compromise while further discussion remains costless. A dated COP1 changes that calculus for every unresolved question the third PrepCom session in March and April left open, particularly the benefit-sharing mechanism for marine genetic resources, which touches directly on what a SIDS delegation can expect to receive from research conducted using its own adjacent high seas.

For a state like Seychelles, this is the same institutional machinery you spent years inside from the delimitation side, now applied to a treaty regime built for jurisdiction that does not belong to any single state. The capacity-building and technology transfer provisions are the section most directly relevant to SHORE's work, and whether they arrive at COP1 as a funded, operating mechanism or as aspirational language deferred again is the single most consequential open question for a hydrospatial institute in a SIDS with no independent high seas research fleet of its own.

Name the sceptical read directly: sixteen months is not long for negotiating a benefit-sharing mechanism from scratch, and precedent from other multilateral environmental agreements suggests capacity-building provisions typically arrive underfunded relative to their drafting ambition regardless of deadline pressure. That is a reasonable prior, and nothing about a fixed date guarantees a good outcome. What the date does guarantee is a visible, trackable moment, in January, where the gap between what BBNJ promised on paper and what it actually delivers on capacity building becomes public and citable, rather than perpetually pending.

The practical takeaway: track the PrepCom's remaining working sessions between now and January specifically for movement on the benefit-sharing and capacity-building text, since that is where the treaty either becomes usable for a state like Seychelles or does not, and January 2027 is now a fixed point to write toward rather than an indefinite horizon.

`https://enb.iisd.org/marine-biodiversity-beyond-national-jurisdiction-bbnj-cop-prepcom3-23mar2026`

07

## Whose data is it once the survey vessel leaves your waters?

*Ocean Networks Canada's pilot on Indigenous ocean data governance is a working model for the exact sovereignty question SHORE has to answer for any hydrospatial dataset collected in Seychelles' waters.*

STORY NOTES

Ocean Networks Canada has launched a year-long pilot with Indigenous coastal communities testing tools for community governance over ocean data, building on Local Contexts, a system of customisable digital labels that let a community set who can access, use, and redistribute data collected in its territory after the collecting institution has moved on.

The mechanism is an attribution and consent layer attached to the data itself, not a block on aggregation or open science. It travels with the dataset rather than staying behind at the point of collection.

The same question applies wherever a foreign research vessel or a multilateral mapping campaign collects hydrospatial data in or near Seychelles' waters: who controls redistribution and downstream use once the data leaves under a standard research permit that was never built to answer that question.

https://www.oceannetworks.ca/news-and-stories/stories/decolonizing-data/

STORY ARTICLE

Ocean research permits have long solved one problem and ignored another. A foreign vessel wanting to survey inside a coastal state's waters needs permission to enter and collect, and that permission process is well established, running through diplomatic notes, research clearances, and national focal points, the machinery you know from the inside as former IOC-UNESCO and International Seabed Authority contact point. What that same permit rarely settles is what happens to the data afterward: who owns downstream use, who gets publication credit, whether the coastal state can set conditions on redistribution once the raw data leaves under a research licence built decades before "open data" became a default expectation of global science funders.

Ocean Networks Canada's pilot is a direct attempt to close that second gap, and it is worth studying closely because the mechanism it is testing, Local Contexts' labelling system, does not require rewriting the underlying legal framework of data collection permits. It attaches a consent and attribution layer to the dataset itself, a set of digital labels a community applies that travel with the data wherever it is subsequently used, rather than trying to control access at the point of collection alone.

The parallel to Seychelles is not analogical, it is structural. Seabed 2030 campaigns, IOC-UNESCO research cruises, and BBNJ-adjacent baseline surveys all involve exactly the same pattern: a foreign or multilateral vessel collects hydrospatial data inside or near a SIDS' waters under a permit focused on entry and collection, and the data then defaults into global open-commons licensing with no mechanism for the coastal state to assert conditions beyond the initial consent. That is not a hypothetical for a future HARMONiSE dataset. It is the existing norm for most bathymetric and ecological data already collected around Seychelles.

Name the open-data objection directly, since it is a serious one: global public goods like the GEBCO grid and BBNJ's science baselines depend on exactly the kind of unrestricted aggregation that a consent-and-attribution layer might complicate, and open-data advocates have real grounds to worry that any friction at the data-sharing stage slows down science that benefits everyone, SIDS included. The Local Contexts model's answer is that attribution and consent conditions are compatible with open aggregation, provided they are built into the data's metadata from the collection stage rather than retrofitted after the dataset has already been merged into a global product with no way to trace conditions back to source.

That timing detail is the actionable one for HARMONiSE specifically. A consent and attribution layer is a design decision that has to happen at the specification stage, not something added later once a dataset already exists without it. Worth treating as a testable requirement in HARMONiSE's next data architecture review, and worth requesting Ocean Networks Canada's actual pilot toolkit directly to see how much of it transfers to a non-Indigenous-specific, small-island sovereignty context where the underlying legal and governance logic, control without full ownership dispute, may map cleanly regardless.

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See also: Local Contexts, digital labelling framework for Indigenous and traditional data governance.

`https://www.oceannetworks.ca/news-and-stories/stories/decolonizing-data/`

N° 08

# A fifty-year-old question about naming the ocean just got answered in Monaco

*The International Hydrographic Organization elected new leadership and adopted a standard for naming every sea and ocean area with a unique digital identifier, and HARMONiSE's data specification needs to align with it now, before the Busan centre starts issuing implementation guidance.*

STORY NOTES

More than 500 delegates from the IHO's 104 member states met in Monaco in April 2026 and elected Rear Admiral Luigi Sinapi of Italy as Secretary-General for a three-year term that began 1 September, with Adam Greenland of New Zealand elected Director. The Assembly adopted S-130, a new standard assigning unique numerical identifiers to ocean and sea areas, resolving a naming and boundary question that had sat open for more than fifty years.

The Assembly also approved an IHO Infrastructure Centre in Busan, South Korea, its first office outside Monaco, built to run the S-100 data framework underpinning next-generation nautical charting.

S-100/S-130 compliance is fast becoming the bar for hydrospatial data to be recognised as authoritative internationally, not merely useful locally.

`https://iho.int/en/historic-outcomes-at-2026-assembly-new-leadership-new-structures-and-global-standards`

STORY ARTICLE

Two outcomes from April's IHO Assembly in Monaco carry direct weight for HARMONiSE, and both took months to surface in wider coverage because hydrographic standards news rarely travels far outside the field itself. The first is leadership: Rear Admiral Luigi Sinapi took over as Secretary-General on 1 September, twelve days before this edition, with Adam Greenland as Director, both now shaping how the organisation's 104 member states coordinate on data standards over the next three years.

The second, S-130, matters more for a working hydrospatial framework. Before this standard, ocean and sea areas had no single authoritative digital identifier system, which sounds like a niche administrative gap until you try to build a dataset that needs to reference "the Western Indian Ocean" or "the Mozambique Channel" in a way that another institution's software can parse unambiguously rather than as a free-text string. Fifty years is a long time for that gap to sit open, and its resolution now gives any hydrospatial project, HARMONiSE included, a stable identifier scheme to build against rather than an ad hoc naming convention that breaks the moment two datasets need to merge.

The Busan Infrastructure Centre is the more consequential structural move. It is the IHO's first office outside Monaco in the organisation's history, built specifically to run the S-100 framework that is meant to replace the ageing S-57 standard behind most current electronic navigational charts. S-100 is explicitly modular, and the pitch behind it, unlike S-57, is that it lowers the technical barrier for smaller producers to contribute standards-compliant data rather than requiring the kind of dedicated hydrographic office infrastructure only larger, wealthier states maintain.

Name the concern a smaller institute should raise before taking that pitch at face value: standards bodies moving toward more centralised global frameworks can just as easily raise the bar for what counts as authoritative, locking out exactly the agile, lower-resource actors S-100's marketing suggests it will include, if the practical implementation guidance ends up assuming infrastructure a SHORE-sized institute does not have. That is a testable question, not a settled one, and it is answerable directly: check HARMONiSE's data schema against the published S-100 test profiles before the Busan centre begins issuing implementation guidance that assumes a baseline this project has not yet verified it meets.

The practical takeaway for this quarter: build S-100/S-130 alignment into HARMONiSE's data specification review now, while the framework is still being operationalised rather than already locked into an implementation pattern that a later retrofit would be more expensive to match.

https://iho.int/en/historic-outcomes-at-2026-assembly-new-leadership-new-structures-and-global-standards

## 09

# Endorsed in July. Invited into two working groups by September. That's the playbook

*A South and Southeast Asian coastal data project just showed exactly what an Ocean Decade endorsement is worth in practice, and it is the template SHORE should be following for the Ocean Mapping Hub, not just admiring from a distance.*

STORY NOTES

The Coastal & Ocean Resilience Data Collaborative, known as CORD, was endorsed as a UN Ocean Decade Action under the Decade's Ocean Practices programme, working to turn fragmented ocean, climate, and socio-economic data into usable insight for coastal communities across South and Southeast Asia.

The CORD team met the Ocean Decade Coordination Office for Ocean Data Sharing in July, and endorsed status moved that conversation from introductions to concrete next steps quickly: invitations to a soon-to-launch Responsible Use of AI Community of Practice and a Tools for Data Sharing Community of Practice followed directly from the endorsement.

This is a working demonstration of what Decade endorsement actually opens, doors that would otherwise take years to find on a cold approach, and it is a direct model for how an Ocean Mapping Hub endorsement bid should be framed and timed.

https://ecomagazine.com/news/coastal/cord-gains-ocean-decade-endorsement-to-unite-coastal-resilience-data-across-asia

STORY ARTICLE

Ocean Decade endorsement is easy to treat as a credential, a line on a project's about page. CORD's experience this year is a useful corrective, because it shows the credential functioning as an actual access mechanism rather than a badge. The project secured endorsement, met the Ocean Decade Coordination Office for Ocean Data Sharing in July, and within roughly two months had invitations to two newly forming communities of practice, one on responsible AI use, one on data sharing tools, both squarely relevant to any project trying to standardise fragmented regional ocean data.

The speed is the part worth naming. CORD's own account of the meeting describes the conversation moving quickly past introductions to concrete next steps specifically because endorsed status changed how the Coordination Office engaged with them. That is a different kind of evidence than a general claim that endorsement "helps visibility." It is a specific, dated sequence: endorsement, then a named meeting, then two named community invitations, each step traceable.

The structural similarity to the Ocean Mapping Hub concept is close enough to be worth stating plainly rather than by analogy. CORD turns fragmented ocean, climate, and socio-economic data into usable insight for coastal communities across a defined multi-country region, South and Southeast Asia. The Ocean Mapping Hub concept does the same thing for hydrospatial and bathymetric data across the Western Indian Ocean. Neither project needs to invent a new problem statement, since the Decade's own endorsement criteria already reward exactly this shape of project: regional, data-fragmentation-focused, community-outcome-oriented.

Name the objection worth taking seriously: one project's fast route through one coordination office is a sample size of one, and CORD may have had prior relationships, a stronger existing dataset, or simply better timing than a first-time applicant would get. That is a fair caution against over-reading a single case study as a guaranteed playbook. What it does establish, at minimum, is that the sequence is achievable and recently demonstrated, which is more than an abstract endorsement application guide provides on its own.

The concrete next step for SHORE: read CORD's actual endorsement application materials if they are public, or reach out to the CORD team directly given the structural similarity of the two projects, before drafting an Ocean Mapping Hub endorsement bid from scratch. There is no reason to reinvent a framing that a comparable project just used successfully this year.

`https://ecomagazine.com/news/coastal/cord-gains-ocean-decade-endorsement-to-unite-coastal-resilience-data-across-asia`

**x.**

## $1.5 billion of $100 billion, and no window built for a state like Seychelles

*UNCTAD puts a hard number on the finance gap you keep arguing anecdotally, and Seychelles' own blue bond, covered elsewhere in this edition, is the closest thing on record to the fix UNCTAD is calling for.*

STORY NOTES

UNCTAD's own framing is blunt: Small Island Developing States received roughly $1.5 billion of the $100 billion in climate finance pledged to developing countries, while contributing under 1 percent of global greenhouse gas emissions. No SIDS-specific window exists under the Green Climate Fund, so small states compete in general pools against far larger, more bureaucratically resourced applicants.

UNCTAD's own language calls the resulting access level "shockingly low," a description that matches the pattern this edition's Seychelles GDP story documents from the other direction: a state whose income classification pushes it further down the concessional finance queue, precisely when its physical exposure argues for the opposite treatment.

Seychelles already built one partial answer to this exact gap: its sovereign blue bond, the first of its kind, raised because concessional public finance was not forthcoming. UNCTAD's call for a SIDS-specific instrument is, in effect, asking multilateral finance to catch up to what Seychelles did unilaterally years ago.

`https://unctad.org/news/blog-climate-finance-sids-shockingly-low-why-needs-change`

STORY ARTICLE

The number is stark on its own terms: $1.5 billion reaching Small Island Developing States out of $100 billion pledged to developing countries overall, against a group of countries responsible for under 1 percent of the emissions driving the crisis they are financing their own adaptation against. UNCTAD's own description, "shockingly low," is not hedged language from an institution that usually hedges.

The mechanism behind the number is structural, not accidental. No SIDS-specific window exists under the Green Climate Fund, so a state applying for adaptation finance competes in the same general pool as far larger developing countries with dedicated climate finance ministries and years of grant-writing infrastructure behind every application. Scale advantages compound here: a $2 million proposal costs nearly as much to prepare and appraise as a $200 million one, so funders rationally favour fewer, larger transactions, and SIDS projects are almost definitionally smaller, since the states themselves are smaller.

This is the direct companion to the GDP-per-capita story elsewhere in this edition, and the two are worth reading together rather than as separate items. Seychelles' income classification is one filter working against concessional access. The absence of any SIDS-specific window is a second, compounding filter that catches SIDS regardless of income level. A state can be locked out on income grounds and, separately, structurally disadvantaged by scale within whatever pool it does qualify for.

Here is the sharper point, and the one worth building a Shorelines piece around rather than restating UNCTAD's finding as received wisdom. Seychelles did not wait for a SIDS-specific multilateral window to appear. It issued the world's first sovereign blue bond, a market-based instrument built specifically because concessional public finance was not forthcoming at the scale or speed a small, exposed economy needed. UNCTAD's call for a SIDS-specific finance instrument is, read plainly, asking the multilateral system to build the kind of dedicated access Seychelles engineered for itself unilaterally, years earlier and under worse terms than a proper concessional window would have offered.

Name the objection a finance ministry would raise: a blue bond is debt, however innovative its structure, and debt-financed resilience is not equivalent to grant-financed resilience, whatever the instrument's design credit. That is correct and worth stating without softening it. The blue bond is evidence of the gap UNCTAD describes, proof that a state was forced toward capital markets because the concessional system failed it, not evidence that the gap has actually been closed. Both stories are true at once, and a piece that holds them together, Seychelles as both innovator and cautionary case, says more than either framed alone.

`https://unctad.org/news/blog-climate-finance-sids-shockingly-low-why-needs-change`